CSE 270 Sports Analytics

Pythagorean wins and winning percentage

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Major League of Baseball



15 teams



15 teams



Major League of Baseball: American League

American League

Division	Team	City
East	Baltimore Orioles	Baltimore, MD
	Boston Red Sox	Boston, MA
	New York Yankees	New York City, NY
	Tampa Bay Rays	St. Petersburg, FL
	Toronto Blue Jays	Toronto, ON
Central	Chicago White Sox	Chicago, IL
	Cleveland Indians	Cleveland, OH
	Detroit Tigers	Detroit, MI
	Kansas City Royals	Kansas City, MO
	Minnesota Twins	Minneapolis, MN
West	Houston Astros	Houston, TX
	Los Angeles Angels	Anaheim, CA
	Oakland Athletics	Oakland, CA
	Seattle Mariners	Seattle, WA
	Texas Rangers	Arlington, TX

Major League of Baseball: National League

National League

Division	Team	City
East	Atlanta Braves	Atlanta, GA
	Miami Marlins	Miami, FL
	New York Mets	New York City, NY
	Philadelphia Phillies	Philadelphia, PA
	Washington Nationals	Washington, D.C.
Central	Chicago Cubs	Chicago, IL
	Cincinnati Reds	Cincinnati, OH
	Milwaukee Brewers	Milwaukee, WI
	Pittsburgh Pirates	Pittsburgh, PA
	St. Louis Cardinals	St. Louis, MO
West	Arizona Diamondbacks	Phoenix, AZ
	Colorado Rockies	Denver, CO
	Los Angeles Dodgers	Los Angeles, CA
	San Diego Padres	San Diego, CA
	San Francisco Giants	San Francisco, CA

Major League of Baseball

Regular Season

The Major League Baseball season runs from the start of April to the end of September, with each club playing 162 games.

Teams normally play "series" of three (occasionally four) games on consecutive days against the same opponent, normally with a "homestand" of two or three series, or a road trip.

Playoffs

At the end of the regular season the three divisional winners and the wild-card team (from each league go forward into the playoffs. The four teams in each league play two series of knockout baseball to determine the who.

The two league winners then meet in the "World Series" (so called, because the first sponsor was the "Daily World" newspaper).

Major League of Baseball

World Series

- Is played between the winners of playoffs of American League and National League.
- Is a best-of-seven tournament. World Series is won by the team who will win 4 games out of 7.

Baseball: The game

Baseball rules explained

https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PLAj29Nf-IKG7V5z9zg3SSJmPVccUtNhQX

Baseball Data

- Lahman season-by-season dataset
  - From authors website
    http://www.seanlahman.com/baseball-archive/statistics/
- Retrosheets game-by-game data, play-by-play data http://www.retrosheet.org/
- PITCHf/x pitch-by-pitch data

Runs and winning percentage

Runs and winning percentage

Lahman teams dataset

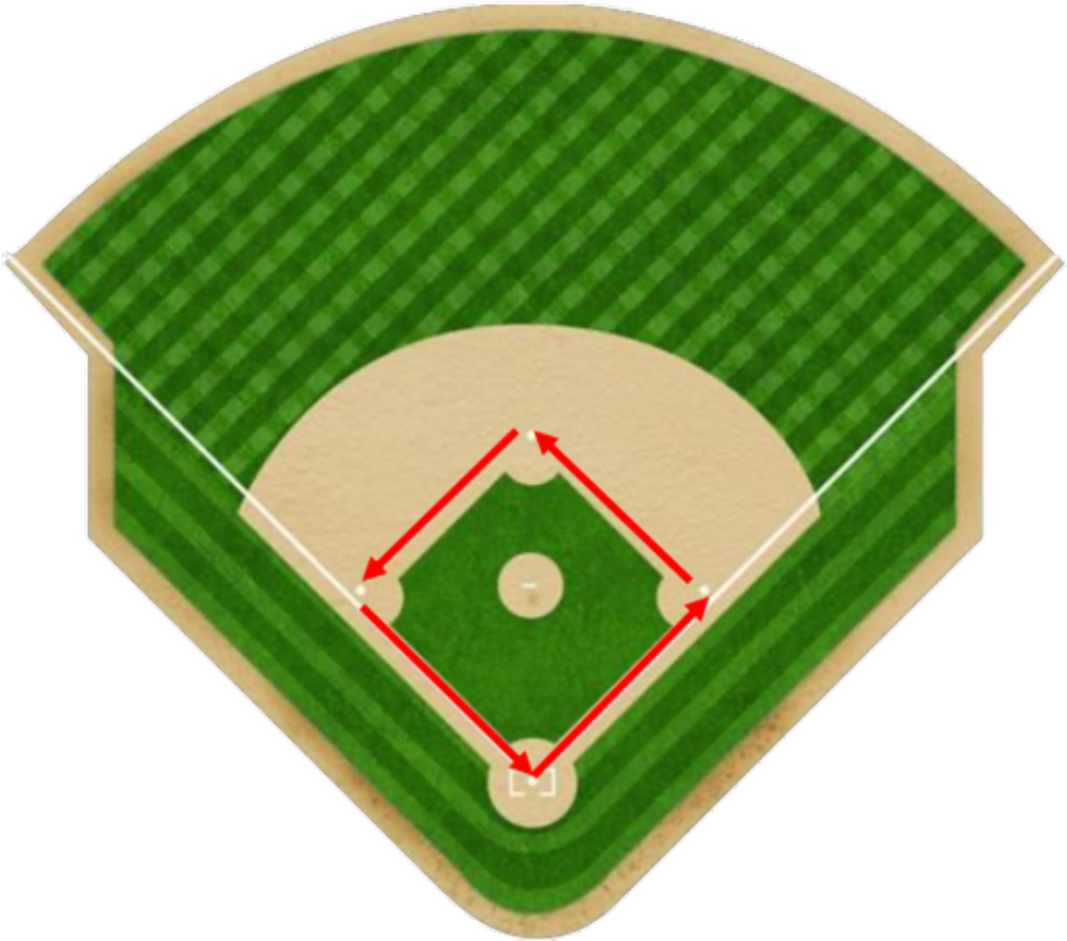
```
library(SportsAnalytics270)
head(mlb_standings)
```

```
##   Season Lig Div                  Team   W  L   G   R  RA Rank
## 1   1999  AL   W       Anaheim Angels  70 92 162 711 826    4
## 2   1999  NL   W Arizona Diamondbacks 100 62 162 908 676    1
## 3   1999  NL   E       Atlanta Braves 103 59 162 840 661    1
## 4   1999  AL   E    Baltimore Orioles  78 84 162 851 815    4
## 5   1999  AL   E       Boston Red Sox  94 68 162 836 718    2
## 6   1999  AL   C    Chicago White Sox  75 86 162 777 870    2
```

Pythagorean wins

In baseball, a run is scored when a player advances around first, second and third base and returns safely to home plate, touching the bases in that order, before three outs are recorded and all obligations to reach base safely on batted balls are met or assured.

The team that scores more runs, wins



Pythagorean wins

We are going to model winning percentage based on Runs allowed and Runs created

- Create two variables:
  Runs differential: Runs-Runs Allowed
  Winning percentage

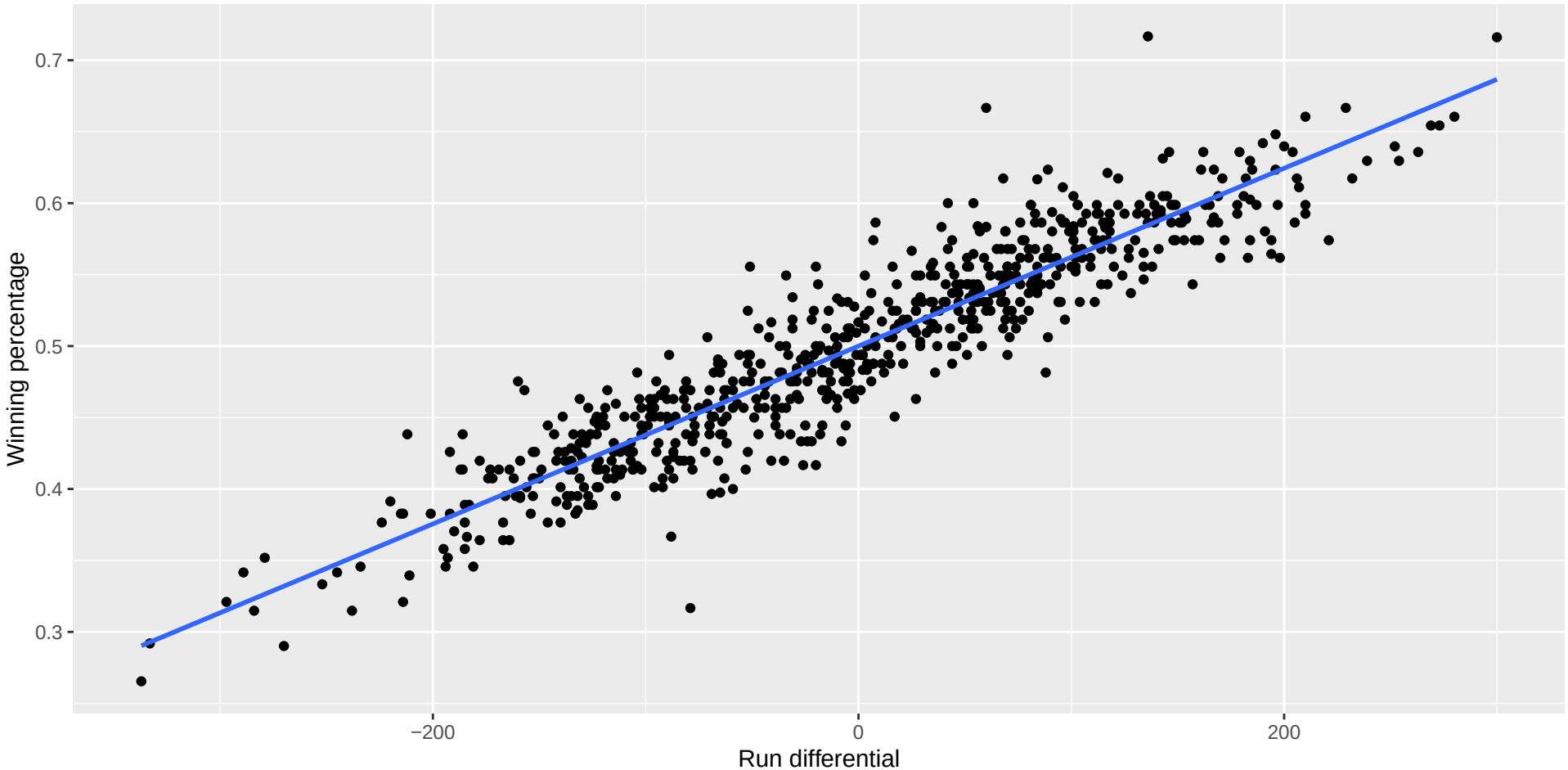
Create Winning Percentage and Run differential

```
# Winning percentage
mlb_standings$Wpct<-mlb_standings$W/(mlb_standings$W+mlb_standings$L)
# Run differential
mlb_standings$RD<-mlb_standings$R-mlb_standings$RA
```

Pythagorean wins

Scatterplot shows clear relationship between Run differential and Winning Percentage

```
library(ggplot2)
ggplot(mlb_standings, aes(x=RD, y=Wpct))+geom_point()+
  geom_smooth(method = "lm", se=F)+
  labs(x="Run differential",y="Winning percentage")
```



Pythagorean wins

Simple linear regression model with Winning percentage as a dependent and Runs differential as an independent variable

$$Wnpct = \beta_0 + \beta_1 * RD + \epsilon$$

```
options(scipen=999)
mod<-lm(Wpct~RD, data=mlb_standings)
summary(mod)
```

```
##
## Call:
## lm(formula = Wpct ~ RD, data = mlb_standings)
##
## Residuals:
##       Min        1Q    Median        3Q       Max
## -0.134163 -0.018132 -0.000172  0.016448  0.132073
##
## Coefficients:
##                Estimate  Std. Error t value            Pr(>|t|)
## (Intercept) 0.499980106 0.001057518  472.79 <0.0000000000000002 ***
## RD          0.000622158 0.000009532   65.27 <0.0000000000000002 ***
## ---
## Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1
##
## Residual standard error: 0.02778 on 688 degrees of freedom
## Multiple R-squared:  0.861,  Adjusted R-squared:  0.8608
## F-statistic:  4260 on 1 and 688 DF,  p-value: < 0.00000000000000022
```

Pythagorean wins

How will you interpret intercept and slope ?

```
coefficients(mod)
```

```
##  (Intercept)           RD
## 0.4999801064 0.0006221576
```

Pythagorean wins

```
coefficients(mod)
```

```
##  (Intercept)           RD
## 0.4999801064 0.0006221576
```

How will you interpret intercept and slope ?

Intercept: If run differential is 0, thus the team makes and allows equal number of runs, then you expect to win 50% of the games.

slope: 1 unit increase in run differential increases the winning percentage by 0.000623.

Pythagorean wins

The predicted value for Winning percentage can be out of Range [0:1]

```
coefficients(mod)
```

```
##  (Intercept)           RD
## 0.4999801064 0.0006221576
```

What will be your prediction for a team with Run differential of 850 ?

Pythagorean formula for Winning percentage

Is derived empirically by Bill James, the founder of Sabermetrics

$$Wpct = \frac{R^2}{R^2 + RA^2}$$

R - runs made
RA - runs allowed

The number of the wins calculated by Pythagorean formula is called ***Pythagorean wins.***

Generic Pythagorean formula

$$Wpct = \frac{R^2}{R^2 + RA^2}$$

The equation can be rewritten in the following way

$\frac{W}{L} = \frac{R^k}{RA^k}$ $log(\frac{W}{L}) = k * log(\frac{R}{RA})$

Now we can fit regression model to find the best value for k

According to Wayne Winston estimates, the best value for k is 1.9

The logic behind Pythagorean formula

- The team wins games in proportion of their "quality" to win.
- Lets say the quality of the team to win is defined by the Run ration

$$\frac{\text{Runs}}{\text{Runs Allowed}}$$

- Team A with runs of 60 and runs allowed of 40 will have quality ratio of 60/40
- Then quality measure of the opponent (all teams collectively) will be 40/60
- Thus to calculate the probability of the team to win:

$$\frac{60/40}{\frac{60}{40}+\frac{40}{60}} = \frac{60^2}{60^2+40^2}$$

Wayne Winston modification

$$Wpct = \frac{R^2}{R^2 + RA^2}$$

$$Wpct = \frac{Rt^2}{Rt^2 + 1} \text{ where, Rt is the runs ration}$$

$$Rt = \frac{\text{Runs}}{\text{Runs allowed}}$$

Usage

$$Wpct = \frac{Rt^2}{Rt^2+1}$$

Suppose a team has scored 850 runs and allowed 800 runs last season.

Rt=850/800=1.0625

Using Pythagorean formula, the predicted winning percentage will be 0.53 or 85.9 games (162*0.53)

Suppose the team trades player A who has created 150 runs for a player who has created 170.

All other things equal this will result the team to score 870 runs. What will happen with winning percentage ?

Rt=870/800 and the predicted winning percentage 0.5418 which translates to 87.7 games.

Buying the player will help the team, to win 2 more games.

Calculate some accuracy measure

Root Mean Square error

$$RMSE = \sqrt{\frac{\sum_{i=1}^{n} (\hat{y}_i - y_i)^2}{n}}$$

```
mlb_standings$PW_percentage<-mlb_standings$R^1.9/(mlb_standings$R^1.9+mlb_standings$

errors<-mlb_standings$Wpct-mlb_standings$PW_percentage

sqrt(mean(errors^2))
```

```
## [1] 0.02556223
```

Our average error is 2.5%, or 0.025

Or it will predict wrongly 4 games (162*0.025)

Pythagorean wins

Now compare error from Pythagorean calculations vs error from regression model

```
mod<-lm(Wpct~RD, data=mlb_standings)
# mod$ residuals gives you the error
sqrt(mean(mod$residuals^2))
```

```
## [1] 0.02773845
```

Pythagorean wins

Bad or good luck ?

https://www.baseball-reference.com/leagues/majors/2018-standings.shtml

```
mlb_standings$PW <- mlb_standings$PW_percentage*(mlb_standings$W+mlb_standings$L)
mlb_standings$PW <- round(mlb_standings$PW,0)
```

```
mlb_standings %>%
  filter(Season == 2018)%>%
  select(Team, W, PW ) %>%
  head()
```

```
##                    Team   W  PW
## 1 Arizona Diamondbacks  82  87
## 2       Atlanta Braves  90  92
## 3    Baltimore Orioles  47  54
## 4       Boston Red Sox 108 104
## 5    Chicago White Sox  62  62
## 6         Chicago Cubs  95  94
```

Pythagorean wins for other

Pythagorean wins for other

Pythagorean wins in NBA

```
library(SportsAnalytics270)
data(nba_east)
data(nba_west)
nba_st <- rbind(nba_east,nba_west)
```

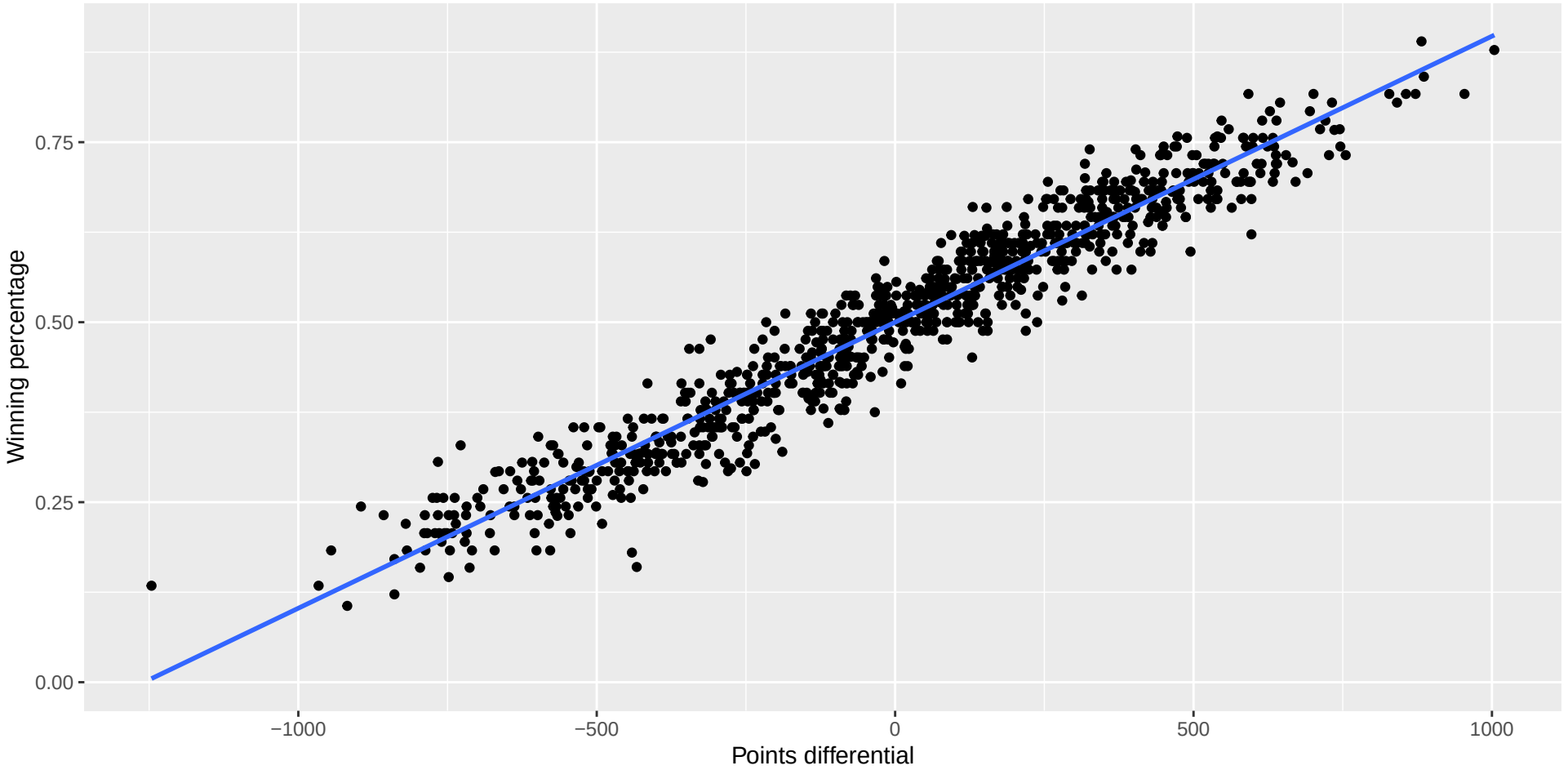
```
head(nba_st)
```

```
##   Rank                Team  W  L   Pct   GB Season   PS   PA
## 1    1       Chicago Bulls 61 21 0.744 <NA>   1991 9024 8278
## 2    2      Boston Celtics 56 26 0.683    5   1991 9145 8668
## 3    3     Detroit Pistons 50 32 0.610   11   1991 8205 7937
## 4    4     Milwaukee Bucks 48 34 0.585   13   1991 8727 8524
## 5    5 Philadelphia 76ers 44 38 0.537   17   1991 8641 8656
## 6    6       Atlanta Hawks 43 39 0.524   18   1991 9003 8940
```

Pythagorean wins in NBA

```
nba_st$PD <- nba_st$PS - nba_st$PA
```

```
ggplot(nba_st, aes(x=PD, y=Pct))+geom_point()+
  geom_smooth(method = "lm", se=F)+
  labs(x="Points differential",y="Winning percentage")
```



Pythagorean wins in NBA

```
options(scipen=999)
model2 <- lm(Pct~PD, data=nba_st)
summary(model2)
```

```
##
## Call:
## lm(formula = Pct ~ PD, data = nba_st)
##
## Residuals:
##       Min         1Q     Median         3Q        Max
## -0.167959 -0.026046  0.000686  0.026404  0.128986
##
## Coefficients:
##                Estimate  Std. Error t value             Pr(>|t|)
## (Intercept) 0.499957299 0.001320843   378.5 <0.0000000000000002 ***
## PD          0.000397225 0.000003514   113.0 <0.0000000000000002 ***
## ---
## Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1
##
## Residual standard error: 0.04041 on 934 degrees of freedom
## Multiple R-squared:  0.9319, Adjusted R-squared:  0.9318
## F-statistic: 1.278e+04 on 1 and 934 DF,  p-value: < 0.00000000000000022
```

Generic Pythagorean formula

Recall:

$$Wpct = \frac{R^2}{R^2 + RA^2}$$

$\frac{W}{L} = \frac{R^k}{RA^k}$ $log(\frac{W}{L}) = k * log(\frac{R}{RA})$

- We want to find the value of k
- General linear regression equation is: $y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X$, however here we have no 01 intercept model, thus $y = \beta_1 X$

Pythagorean wins in NBA

0 at the beginning of the right hand of the regression equation, indicates that we are fitting no intercept model

```
nba_st$Ratio <- nba_st$PS/nba_st$PA
```

```
model2 <- lm(log(W/L)~0+log(Ratio), data=nba_st)
```

Pythagorean wins in NBA

```
summary(model2)
```

```
##
## Call:
## lm(formula = log(W/L) ~ 0 + log(Ratio), data = nba_st)
##
## Residuals:
##      Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
## -0.57330 -0.11685 -0.00234  0.10699  0.71458
##
## Coefficients:
##             Estimate Std. Error t value            Pr(>|t|)
## log(Ratio)  14.0254     0.1186   118.3 <0.0000000000000002 ***
## ---
## Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1
##
## Residual standard error: 0.1693 on 935 degrees of freedom
## Multiple R-squared:  0.9373, Adjusted R-squared:  0.9373
## F-statistic: 1.398e+04 on 1 and 935 DF,  p-value: < 0.00000000000000022
```

Pythagorean wins in NBA

The estimated value of K is 14.093

W Pyth

Pythagorean Wins; the formula is G * (Tm PTS^{14} / (Tm PTS^{14} + Opp PTS^{14})). The formula was obtained by fitting a logistic regression model with log(Tm PTS / Opp PTS) as the explanatory variable. Using this formula for all BAA, NBA, and ABA seasons, the root mean-square error (rmse) is 3.14 wins. Using an exponent of 16.5 (a common choice), the rmse is 3.48 wins. (Note: An exponent of 10 is used for the WNBA.)

from: https://www.basketball-reference.com/about/glossary.html#wins_pyth

Pythagorean wins in NBA

```
nba_st$PW <- nba_st$PS^14.093/(nba_st$PS^14.093+nba_st$PA^14.093)
sqrt(mean((nba_st$PW-nba_st$Pct)^2))
```

```
## [1] 0.03740816
```

```
82*0.0367104
```

```
## [1] 3.010253
```

On average we are going to be "wrong" by 3 games per team

Pythagorean wins in NBA

Lets have a look at the last season only

Create variable PW_G, Pythagorean expected wins

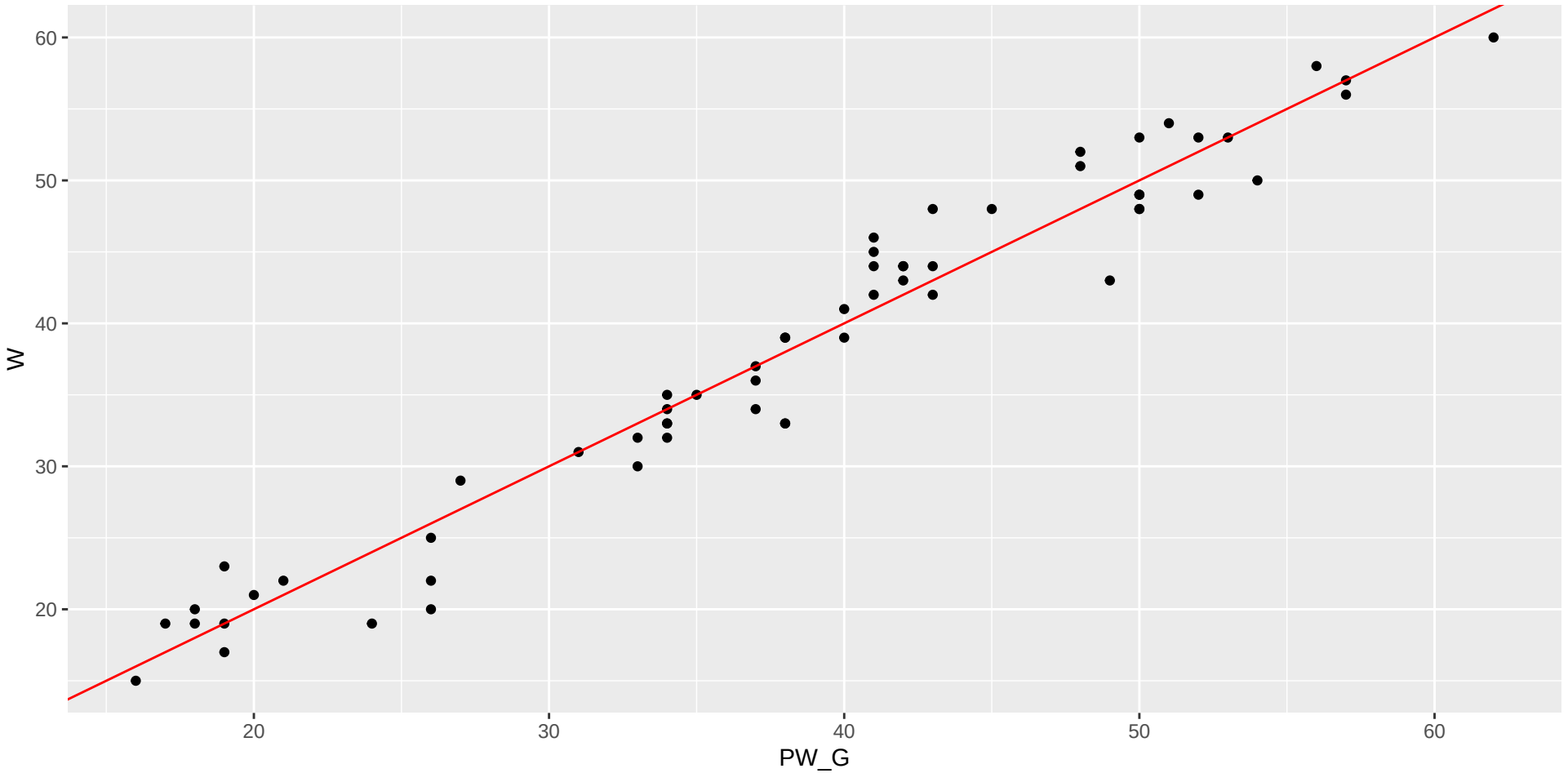
```
nba_st$G <- nba_st$W+nba_st$L
nba_st$PW_G <- round(nba_st$PW*nba_st$G)
nba_st %>% filter(Season==2019) %>% head()
```

```
##   Rank                Team  W  L   Pct   GB Season   PS   PA  PD     Ratio
## 1    1    Milwaukee Bucks 60 22 0.732 <NA>   2019 9686 8959 727 1.0811474
## 2    2    Toronto Raptors 58 24 0.707    2   2019 9384 8885 499 1.0561621
## 3    3 Philadelphia 76ers 51 31 0.622    9   2019 9445 9224 221 1.0239592
## 4    4     Boston Celtics 49 33 0.598   11   2019 9216 8852 364 1.0411207
## 5    5     Indiana Pacers 48 34 0.585   12   2019 8857 8584 273 1.0318034
## 6    6      Brooklyn Nets 42 40 0.512   18   2019 9204 9210  -6 0.9993485
##           PW  G PW_G
## 1 0.7501809 82   62
## 2 0.6835349 82   56
## 3 0.5826535 82   48
## 4 0.6382820 82   52
## 5 0.6085509 82   50
## 6 0.4977040 82   41
```

Pythagorean wins in NBA

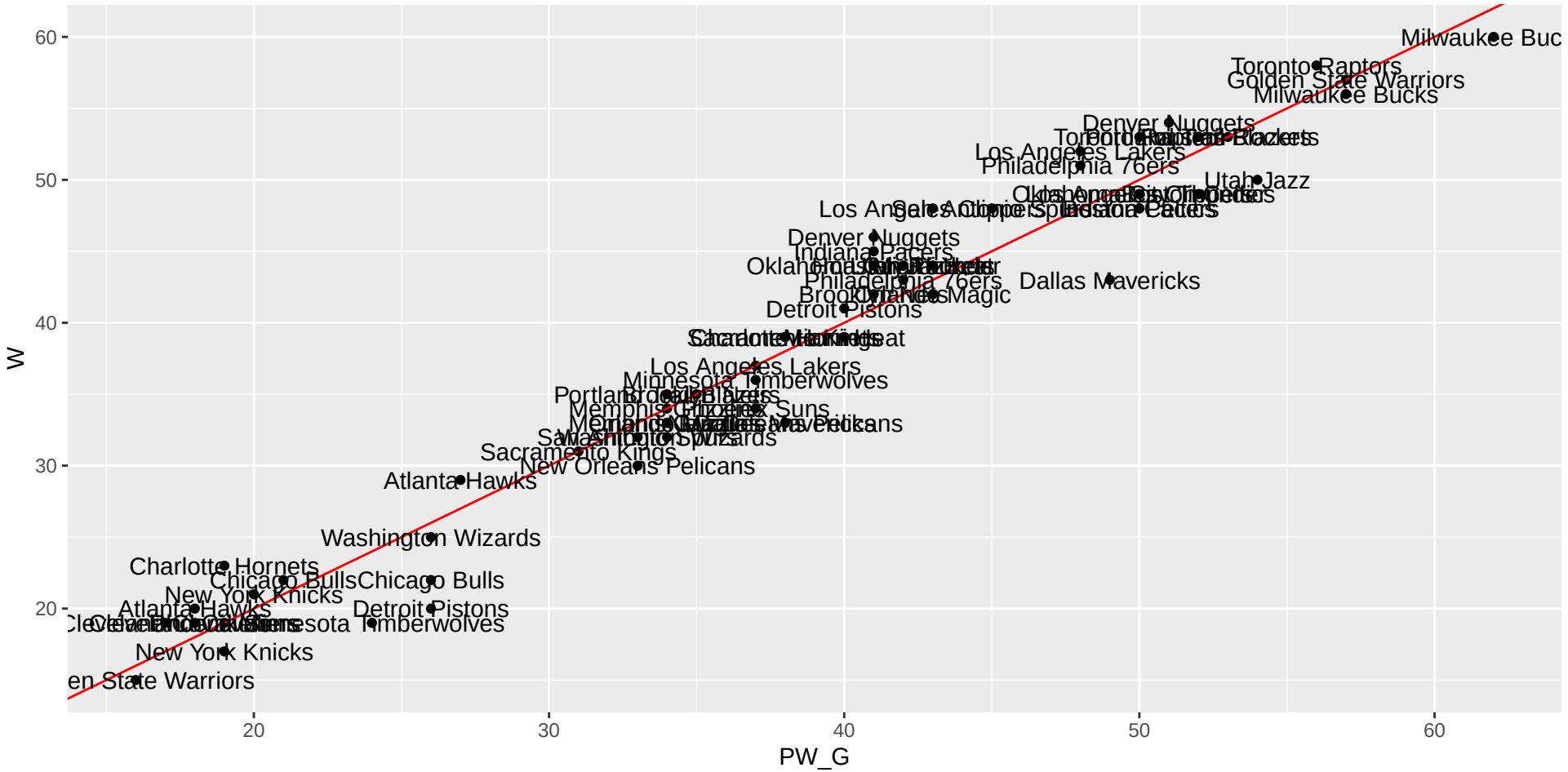
teams above the line are "lucky", below the line are "unlucky"

```
nba_st %>% filter(Season==2019)%>%
  ggplot(aes(x=PW_G, y=W))+geom_point()+
  geom_abline(intercept =0 , slope = 1, col='red')
```



Pythagorean wins in NBA

```
nba_st %>% filter(Season==2019)%>%
  ggplot(aes(x=PW_G, y=W, label=Team))+geom_point()+
  geom_abline(intercept =0 , slope = 1, col='red')+
  geom_text()
```



Pythagorean wins for other sports

Pythagorean wins are also calculated for other sports.

$$\text{in NFL}$$

$$Win = \frac{\text{points for}^{2.37}}{\text{points for}^{2.37} + \text{points against}^{2.37}}$$